that be in the MPCC were involved in machinations to deny him the party nomination. Thorat admitted that he was "*vyathit*" (upset or hurt). Though he did not take any names, it was clear he was referring to Patole. The BJP has extended an open invite to Thorat, but his old party colleagues call him a "legacy Congressman" and insist he will not leave the party. The party's central leadership has also rejected Thorat's resignation.

Meanwhile, the unseemly episode has led to Patole's opponents, like former MLA Ashish Deshmukh, demanding the MPCC chief's resignation. Party veterans see this as an unfortunate souring of a promising situation. "When Patole was appointed as state unit president, he had no baggage. He was seen as his own man, not part of any clique

NANA PATOLE'S SUPPOSEDLY 'AUTHORITARIAN' STYLE HAS CAUSED A CHURN WITHIN THE MAHARASHTRA CONGRESS

led by established leaders," points out a senior Congress leader and former minister. "But he complicated things by not adopting a consultative approach and shunning teamwork. His style was seen as authoritarian."

Even before the present fracas, Patole's helmsmanship of the Congress had been accompanied by quite a bit of turbulence. Indeed, he was in a way central to the dramatic denouement the MVA regime faced last year. After he was appointed MPCC president in February 2021, Patole had quit as the Maharashtra assembly Speaker. Then governor B.S. Koshyari sat on the MVA government's request to call for elections to fill the post, and consequently it remained vacant. Sanjay Raut, Rajya Sabha MP of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), has reiterated that Patole had acted in haste. Had he stuck on as Speaker, the MVA government under Uddhav Thackeray would have been saved as he could have disqualified Eknath Shinde and his 39 rebel legislators. However, Patole said his decision to step down had been prompted by then Congress president Sonia Gandhi.

After taking charge as MPCC president, Patole had also rubbed the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and the Shiv Sena the wrong way by claiming the Congress would fight elections alone. He also complained of irregularities in the energy department helmed by party colleague Nitin Raut. Then, in December 2021, Patole declared in Bhandara district that he could "beat" or "abuse" Modi. While irate BJP workers took to the streets, Patole claimed unconvincingly that he was referring to a local goon who was the prime minister's namesake.

Despite demands for his ouster, chances are that Patole may stay. He is seen as the choice of senior leader Rahul Gandhi and national general secretary K.C. Venugopal. Also, he carries the image of a permanent rebel in politics. A Congress MLA from Lakhandur in Bhandara in 1999 and 2004, he rebelled in 2009, citing the then Congress-NCP regime's failure to address the woes of paddy farmers. The same year, fighting the assembly election on a BJP ticket, he registered another victory. In 2014, he entered the Lok Sabha as a giant-killer by defeating NCP leader and then Union minister Praful Patel. Once again taking up the cause of farmers, Patole quit the BJP and his Lok Sabha seat in 2017 after criticising Modi over agrarian distress. He later unsuccessfully fought the 2019 Lok Sabha polls from Nagpur against Union minister Nitin Gadkari.

Patole denies any infighting within the party. "The issue is over now," he told INDIA TODAY, when asked about Thorat's resignation. Patole loyalists say he has begun reviving the Congress in Maharashtra. This month, the party won two crucial legislative council elections—that too from BJP strongholds Nagpur and Amravati. "Eventually, it's the future of the party that matters, not that of individual leaders. Nanabhau does not come from a family that has a background in politics; hence, dynasts within the party are upset with his rise," explains an aide. But even with disruption as a marker of positive change, Patole may have to add a bit of tact to succeed. ■

WEST BENGAL

ADANI IN

By Romita Datta

How one of India's mightiest industrialists has fallen in Mamata Banerjee's esteem! Till the other day, the West Bengal chief minister was boasting about Gautam Adani's declared intent of investing Rs 10,000 crore in the state—a promise that had come at the Bengal Global Business Summit in April 2022. The impending development of the Rs 25,000-crore deep sea port at Tajpur by the Adani Group too was being touted as a milestone achievement of her government. But with the group caught in the furore over the Hindenburg report, Mamata has attacked him as an *adaar byapari* ('ginger trader', or a small-time trader). The political storm around Adani has made the state government go quiet on its own deals with the billionaire. It now claims total ignorance about the purchase of land for a project by Adani Power in 2022 that has spawned unrest amongst villagers in Murshidabad district. The charges they level are serious enough and not the sort that Mamata, especially with her Singur agitation past, would ideally like to have haunting her: alleged forcible acquisition of land along with low compensation.

Adani Power Ltd, under a bilateral agreement signed during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 2015 Dhaka visit, is setting up a 1,600 megawatt thermal power project at Godda in Jharkhand for supplying electricity to Bangladesh, in collaboration with the Bangladesh Power Development Board (BPDB). High-voltage transmission lines from Godda have been drawn for the purpose, cutting through Bengal before entering Bogura and Rongpur in Bangladesh. The lines, supposed to transmit 400,000 volts of power, traverse 44 km in Bengal over six villages of Beniagram panchayat in Murshidabad's Farakka block, includ-